

STAGE SIX • COMMUNICATION: SPEAKING, READING & WRITING

FIRSTS

GROUP VERSIONS OF KEY EXERCISES

Live, group-adapted versions of the FIRSTS that benefit most from interaction

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Group Versions of Key Exercises

Stage Six • Communication: Speaking, Reading & Writing

PURPOSE

Communication is fundamentally interpersonal, which makes Stage Six, more than almost any other stage, benefit from live, social versions of its exercises. You cannot fully judge your own email clarity, speaking presence, listening habits, or feedback delivery without genuine outside interaction — these are skills that only fully reveal themselves in exchange with another person.

This document adapts twelve FIRSTS across all six sections of Stage Six into pair, small-group, or role-play formats. As with every stage, these are additions, not replacements — participants complete their own individual work first, and the group version tests or deepens it. Twelve was a deliberate choice for a seventy-FIRST stage: rather than adapting every possible candidate, these are the ones where outside interaction is genuinely load-bearing to the skill itself, not just a nice-to-have.

Given this stage's overall volume, the companion Session Plan recommends running only 3–4 of these live per session rather than all twelve in one sitting — pick the ones that best fit your cohort's real needs and energy.

The Twelve Adapted Exercises

FIRST I1

Professional Email Sent — Subject Line Swap

TIME: +10 min beyond solo drafting

1. After drafting individually, pairs swap only the subject line and opening two sentences, without the rest of the email.
2. Partner guesses what the email is actually asking for, based only on those two elements.
3. Compare the guess to the real ask — how close was it?

FACILITATOR NOTE

If the subject line and opening alone don't communicate the real ask, the email likely buries it too deep — a fast, genuine clarity test.

FIRST I5

Public Speaking Recording — Paired Playback Review

TIME: +15 min beyond solo recording

1. Participants record individually, then pair up.
2. Each person watches their own recording once privately, then watches their partner's recording once.
3. Partner shares one specific thing they noticed that the speaker likely couldn't hear in their own head (a filler word pattern, a pacing tic).

FACILITATOR NOTE

Outside ears reliably catch patterns the speaker has genuinely tuned out in their own voice — this is more useful paired than solo.

FIRST I20

Storytelling Exercise — Fact-to-Story Relay

TIME: +15 min beyond solo drafting

1. Small groups of 3–4. Each person shares one plain fact about a real project or experience (no story yet).
2. The group collectively helps reframe it as a short narrative with a beginning, tension, and resolution.
3. Compare the flat fact to the group-built story — what changed?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Turning someone else's fact into a story is often easier than doing it for your own experience, and the process reveals the actual narrative structure being taught.

FIRST I23

Debate Participation — Structured Mini-Debate

TIME: +25 min beyond framing

1. Divide into small teams of 2–3. Assign each team a side of a genuine, debatable, low-stakes topic (not politically charged).
2. Give 5 minutes of prep time, then run 2-minute opening statements per side, followed by a brief rebuttal round.
3. Debrief as a full group: which arguments held up under the rebuttal, and which fell apart?

FACILITATOR NOTE

A real, structured debate format teaches evidence-based argument far more effectively than discussing the concept abstractly.

FIRST I28

Group Presentation Coordinated — Relay Presentation

TIME: +25 min beyond individual prep

1. Small groups of 3–4 are given a shared topic and must divide it into sections, each person owning one part.
2. Run the full presentation live, back to back, with each person picking up exactly where the last left off.
3. Debrief: where did the handoffs feel smooth, and where did the presentation lose coherence?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Handoff moments are where group presentations most often break down; a live relay run makes those specific seams visible in a way individual rehearsal never does.

FIRST I29

Impromptu Speaking Drill — Random Prompt Circle

TIME: +15 min beyond framing

1. Sit in a circle. Prepare a stack of prompt cards (professional and light topics mixed).
2. Going around the circle, each person draws a card and speaks for 45 seconds with zero prep time.
3. No feedback between turns — keep the pace brisk so nerves don't have time to build before each turn.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Speed and lack of individual feedback are deliberate here; the goal is volume of reps in a low-pressure, fast-moving format, not polish on any single answer.

FIRST I42

Conflict Resolution Conversation — Role-Play Pairs

TIME: +20 min beyond framing

1. Pairs. Give each pair a realistic, mild workplace conflict scenario (a missed deadline, a miscommunication about ownership).

2. One person role-plays raising the issue, the other role-plays receiving it professionally. Run for 3–4 minutes, then swap roles with a new scenario.
3. Debrief: what language felt natural to use when raising a real concern directly?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Role-play makes the discomfort of raising conflict tangible in a genuinely safe setting, which is exactly the rehearsal most people never get before a real one arises.

FIRST I45

Meeting Facilitation in Class/Group — Rotating Facilitator

TIME: +20 min beyond framing

1. Run a real 10-minute group discussion on a genuine, relevant topic.
2. Rotate the facilitator role every 2–3 minutes without pausing the discussion — each new facilitator must pick up the thread and keep it moving.
3. Debrief: what did each facilitator do differently to redirect or summarize?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Rotating mid-discussion forces genuine adaptive facilitation rather than a single person's prepared approach, and gives everyone real practice in the seat.

FIRST I7

Feedback Response — Live Feedback Round

TIME: +15 min beyond framing

1. Pairs. Partner A shares a real piece of their own work (writing, a presentation outline, anything genuine).
2. Partner B gives one honest piece of critical feedback. Partner A's only job is to respond without explaining or defending — just acknowledging and asking a genuine clarifying question.
3. Swap roles.

FACILITATOR NOTE

The instruction to not explain or defend is the entire exercise — most people's instinct is immediate justification, and practicing suppressing that instinct is the real skill being built.

FIRST I25

Professional Feedback Given — Structured Feedback Practice

TIME: +15 min beyond framing

1. Pairs. Partner A shares a real piece of work.
2. Partner B gives feedback using a specific structure: one genuine strength, one specific, actionable improvement, framed kindly but directly.
3. Partner A confirms whether the feedback felt genuinely useful and specific enough to act on.

FACILITATOR NOTE

The structure (strength, then one specific improvement) prevents both empty praise and vague, unhelpful criticism — model this explicitly before pairs begin.

FIRST I17

Cross-Cultural Communication Exercise — Perspective Panel

TIME: +20 min beyond framing

1. If your cohort has genuine cultural or regional diversity, invite 2–3 volunteers to briefly share one communication norm from their background that differs from what's typically assumed as “default” professional style.
2. Open a short group discussion: what assumptions do we make about “normal” communication that aren't actually universal?

FACILITATOR NOTE

This only works well with genuine, willing volunteers — never put someone on the spot to represent their culture if they haven't opted in. Adjust to a researched-example format if your cohort lacks this kind of diversity or volunteers aren't comfortable.

FIRST I52

Active Note-Taking System — Compare-Your-Notes

TIME: +10 min beyond individual practice

1. After the icebreaker's note-taking round or a short lecture segment, have participants compare their notes in pairs.
2. Identify what one partner captured that the other missed, and vice versa.
3. Discuss: what made the captured points genuinely worth writing down versus the parts left out?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Seeing a genuinely different but equally valid set of notes on the same content reveals that active note-taking is a selection skill, not just a speed skill.